

## IAC Awards 2009

Kalamazoo won the best agency, and Design Lab won the award for the best e-mail campaign at the recent Internet Advertising Competition awards 2009

## No ads on Twitter

Advertising is still not a part of the road-map of Twitter, although they may show up down the line

## Socialising

Popular campaigns, such as Vodafone's ZooZos, had close to 3,20,000 fans. Facebook's fan pages allow you to embed videos, pictures, update information, and more. Apart from a web site, or a blog, a wholly social media driven campaign can be launched from Facebook itself.

Most social networking sites also have groups and forums. This allows for active user engagement with questions, answers, discussions on topics of interest, and more.

LinkedIn (www.Linkedin.com) is also a good place to start. It focuses on professional networking, and as with other sites, allows you to expand your network and create groups. It also allows you to create an official company page, and this is something you should certainly do.

If you're looking to promote your company's image, LinkedIn is the place you should start. However, if you're trying to increase the popularity of your products and/or services, you will be better off

looking at sites such as Facebook first. However, you should still do both, it's just that you have to get your priorities right, base don what it is you're trying to achieve for yourself.



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## Become a star!

If you're running an online campaign, multimedia sharing is essential. What you need to do is launch simultaneously on several platforms. The web site, the blog, the social networking account, Twitter and of course, the multimedia sites. For videos, YouTube is the most popular destination. Create a YouTube channel for yourself, and keep uploading videos. If it's still images that you want to use, Flickr is your best bet for a host.

## Too much info?

If you're looking at information sharing, remember, the focus is more on brand reputation and brand awareness, as opposed to direct marketing. Sites such as www.mouthshut.com have user ratings for brands. Forums such as Yahoo! QnA, Rediff QnA (Questions and Answers) have users commenting and asking questions about brands. It is essential to revert back to these questions and answer as truthfully and as positively as possible. Having a page on Wikipedia is considered mandatory nowadays. Wikis and QnA sites, along with product review sites like MouthShut or ThinkDigit help a lot in terms of information sharing and brand reputation.

## Microblogging

If you find something interesting, Tweet it. The principle is simple. Follow people who are interesting, get followed by people who think you are interesting. Update your status message regularly, and tell people what you think / what you're doing. Twitter is a very good platform to engage with people. It's completely unobtrusive. Plus, it's free and simple to use.

Indigo Nation started a "Wacky at Work" contest which asked users to send crazy pictures of them at work. Cadbury started a "Gift a Chocolate"

application on Facebook this Diwali. The application was extremely popular and turns up the moment you search for "Facebook Happy Diwali". US president Barack Obama uses social media, and is one of the most followed celebrities on Twitter — both before and after becoming President. The Sunsilk Gang of Girls site for women was popular only for a while. The Jaago Re campaign against corruption / for voting by Tata Tea utilises a micro-site along with social networking. Of course, for good success stories, check the ZooZoo campaign.

## THE INTEGRATION

1. Create a web site.
2. Create a blog. Direct people from your blog to your web site and vice versa.
3. Use SEO for your web site.
4. Use SEM (contextual advertising) and display ads for your brand. Display ads should link back to your web site
5. Create a Wikipedia page.
6. Create a Facebook and Twitter account.
7. Create LinkedIn, YouTube, Flickr and other accounts if deemed essential
8. Release updates to engage with your audience as multimedia / conversations
9. Simultaneous updates on your blog, Facebook fan page, Twitter, etc.
10. Once there is some interesting content, start gaining followers and fans on Facebook and Twitter
11. Use e-mail marketing once you have a loyal group who won't mind e-mails. This is a basic online marketing campaign guide. However, to personalise this, try being innovative. Try engaging users by asking them to upload multimedia.

When it comes to cost, and popularity, social media is still growing. Though the cost is close to zero, the lack of knowledge prevents most brands and companies from experimenting with it. The marketing trend in India mirrors the West, though with a far lower budget. Search Marketing accounts for 60.1 per cent of all digital media marketing budgets, display advertising accounts for 30 per cent, and social media, 2.8 per cent. Online media as a whole accounts for 12 per cent of all advertising expenditure. So don't sit around, get started; make some money. 

## BEST PRACTICES

1. Create a fan page / official brand account (fan page recommended) (alternatively create a forum)
2. Regular interaction with regular content sharing – videos, pictures, links
3. Any press release, notification, on web site / blog should be accompanied with release of content on the fan page urging active discussion
4. Invite friends and fans. Start by inviting trusted associates / employees of the company. Build a good user base, then start inviting friends of known people.
5. Have a personality. While on Twitter, it is essential that your brand have a personality. Hence, humorous and opinionated tweets are appreciated
6. Engage your followers. If someone comments on your tweet, reply back. Chat. Also, re-tweeting your followers' tweets will earn you re-tweets yourself, which helps spread your word / brand around.
7. Do not have too many updates in a day. Flooding someone's feed with mindless tweets is irritating and frowned upon.
8. Use hash tags #<campaign name> if running a campaign with some specific name. A good example is the #moonfruit campaign which was so popular, it was the trending topic on Twitter for days.